for instance, may not be in a position to curb the various militant proxies that it nurtured over the years even if it wants to, given the expected blowback. But it also could not just continue nurturing these groups given the proactive regional pushback. The recent failures of the Afghan Taliban to credibly capture Kunduz or Helmand (or to gain control of the Kandahar airfield), and that of the LeT to substantially infiltrate into India-administered Kashmir, then, only increased Pakistan's operational costs of cultivating and sustaining these so-called strategic assets. In such a scenario, where the cost of supporting proxies seemed higher than the accruing benefits, talking to India on traditional bilateral disputes, but also on Afghanistan, was an attractive option. Pakistan's treatment of Afghanistan as a taboo topic (with India) only toughened New Delhi's resolve to maintain its presence in Kabul and contain Pakistan's influence.

The timing suited India as well. Already under pressure from the US to open talks with Pakistan, New Delhi employed a variety of coercive methods ranging from no talks and heavy firing along the border to, allegedly, increasing covert funding and support to various anti-government elements in Karachi, Balochistan (via Afghanistan), and Pakistan-administered Kashmir (big protests were held in Muzzafarabad, Gilgit and Kotli seeking 'freedom' from Pakistan), to pressurise Islamabad.[8] Responding to Islamabad's overtures for talks was imperative to reap the benefits of its proactive Pakistan policy on the negotiation table. Indian PM Narendra Modi's strong mandate and the Pakistan military's consolidation of power after the 16 December 2014, Army Public School massacre (that resulted in the death of 141 people of whom 132 were children) made it viable for such talks to succeed.[9] Ghani's steadfast engagement with Pakistan also helped India's quest for resolving differences with Islamabad by creating a conciliatory environment across the region, instead of being stuck in a dangerous cold-peace/hot-war dynamic that only promised instability and insecurity. Not surprisingly, within a week of the official launch of the comprehensive bilateral dialogue, the Turkmenistan-Afghanistan-Pakistan-India (TAPI) pipeline was inaugurated.[10] Such were the hopes that Modi, in his address to the Afghan parliament two weeks later said: 'I hope that Pakistan will become a bridge between South Asia and Afghanistan and beyond'.[11] Indian policymakers also reluctantly welcomed the Quadrilateral Coordination Group (QCG)